

Maine Fire Departments Say Software Costs Surged After Industry Buyouts

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As small Maine fire departments struggle with rising costs for trucks and equipment, some chiefs say another expense has quietly surged: the software they rely on to track emergency calls, training records and payroll.

Several departments tell the CBS13 I-Team their annual bills doubled or even tripled after their longtime software providers were sold and consolidated into larger companies.

'The Backbone of What We Do'

"It's really the backbone of what we do for information in our department," Bridgton Fire Chief Glen Garland said. "Without it, we'd just be completely lost."

Garland's department had used the same reporting software for nearly 25 years. But last year, the company was sold — and Garland says that's when the pricing changed and he felt pressured to lock into a long-term contract.

"They were really putting on quite a bit of high-pressure sales to get you to lock into a four- or five-year contract," Garland said. "It was going to go from around \$2,500 a year up to \$15,000 in five years, and there was no reason given for that. I asked specifically, are we getting more product for this increase in dollars? And the answer was no — we're just catching up."

For a small town department, Garland says, that kind of jump would have been difficult to explain to taxpayers. "It's just a big increase in a relatively small budget," Garland said.

Buyouts and Consolidation

The company that acquired Bridgton's provider is ESO Solutions, a Texas-based firm that develops software for health care systems and first responders.

Backed by private equity investors, ESO has purchased several smaller companies in recent years, including Emergency Reporting — a platform used by many volunteer departments across Maine. That platform is now being phased out.

In Rockport, Fire Chief Jason Peasley says his department used Emergency Reporting for more than a decade. "We had 13 years of all of our training records, all of our incident reporting — everything we used was on that one system," Peasley said. "By switching, I would lose all those records."

Peasley says the transition left his department little choice but to move to ESO's system — at a significantly higher price. "It's about a 110% increase from what we were paying two years ago to today," Peasley said. Asked if that represents a significant budget impact, he responded: "Any increase for any budget, especially where we are today. Every little penny counts."

The I-Team reached out to ESO to ask what factors have driven price increases reported by agencies in Maine and how they approach pricing for small budget-constrained fire and EMS departments. The company did not respond.

However, the company's CEO told the New York Times during an interview in December that the software businesses they acquired were on an unsustainable footing and needed investments or pricing adjustments to make them viable into the future. "If you aren't on a sustainable path, you can't reinvest, you can't ensure compliance, you can't ensure innovation," ESO CEO Eric Beck stated to the Times. ESO now serves thousands of fire, EMS and health care agencies nationwide.

Why Private Equity Is Interested

Peter Lane, a professor of strategy and leadership at the University of New Hampshire's Paul College of Business and Economics, says sometimes the most unlikely industries can be especially attractive to private equity firms. These firms typically buy established companies with the goal of increasing profitability and reducing costs. "They come in, buy them up, and their hope is to improve the value of the business," Lane said.

Unlike volatile industries tied to consumer trends, fire and EMS software is funded largely by municipal budgets — meaning revenue tends to be steady and predictable. "Private equity companies aren't chasing flashy logos. They're looking for predictable, stable cash flows which often come in seemingly boring businesses," Lane explained.

Lane says acquisitions can sometimes lead to technology upgrades, expanded services or operational efficiencies. But as more competitors are absorbed into fewer companies, customers may face fewer choices and possibly higher prices. "Consolidation is going to be bad for customers anyway, and private equity just accelerates that," Lane said. "Sometimes, they buy companies that are competing with the ones they've already bought just so they can buy them and shut them down. That's a strategy that makes sense for the company and their investors, but it's not necessarily good for the consumer."

Few Alternatives

Garland in Bridgton ultimately cut ties with ESO and found a lower-priced option from one of the remaining independent software providers. Still, switching systems wasn't easy. "I was concerned about making that jump when we have a bunch of people that like to put out fires but don't like to work on a computer," Garland said.

He says what departments need now is stability in the industry. "Quite frankly, I wouldn't want to go through it again if I didn't have to," Garland stated.

The state of Maine offers a free reporting system for fire and EMS agencies. However, departments say it handles only basic federal reporting requirements and lacks many of the features provided by commercial

systems. Even so, some small departments told the I-Team they may ultimately switch to the state system for cost savings alone.

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